

The Life and Teachings of Mevlānā Jelālu-'d-Dīn Rūmī: A Synthesis of the *Mesnevī* Anecdotes

Executive Summary

This briefing document synthesizes the historical accounts and hagiographic anecdotes surrounding Jelālu-'d-Dīn Rūmī, the 13th-century sage, poet, and founder of the Mevlevī dervish order. Based on the records of the historian El Eflākī, the primary themes include the spiritual lineage of the "Sultans of Science," the transformative influence of Shemsu-'d-Dīn Tebrīzī, and the composition of the *Mesnevī* as a pedagogical tool for spiritual awakening. **Critical**

Takeaways:

- **Spiritual Lineage:** Jelāl was born into a family of high religious and royal standing in Balkh, claiming descent from Abū-Bekr. His father, Bahā'u-'d-Dīn Veled, was a renowned scholar whose flight from the Mongol invasion led the family to Qonya.
- **The Catalyst of Shemsu-'d-Dīn:** The arrival of Shemsu-'d-Dīn Tebrīzī transformed Jelāl from a traditional professor into an ecstatic mystic. The subsequent disappearance or murder of Shems prompted the institution of the Mevlevī musical and dancing rituals as a form of mourning and devotion.
- **The *Mesnevī*:** Composed at the urging of Husāmu-'d-Dīn, the *Mesnevī* serves as an exposition of the "mysteries of the Qur'ān," designed to entice the "Romans" (Anatolians) toward divine love through the "bait of sweet sounds."
- **Universalism and Ethics:** The anecdotes emphasize Jelāl's radical humility, his respect for all faiths (including Jews and Christians), and his teaching that the heart—not external ritual—is the true site of divine encounter.

I. Ancestry and Early Life

The sources establish a prestigious dual lineage for Jelālu-'d-Dīn, combining spiritual authority with royal blood.

- **Genealogical Foundations:** Jelāl was of the race of Abū-Bekr, the first Caliph of Islam. His ancestors were among the original Muslim conquerors of Khurāsān. On his maternal side, he was descended from the Kh'ārezmian royal house and the great Imām Es-Sarakhsī.
- **The Flight from Balkh:** His father, Bahā'u-'d-Dīn Veled (Sultānu-'l-'Ulemā), was a powerful preacher in Balkh. Foretelling the Mongol destruction of the city by Jengīz Khān, he led a small suite out of Khurāsān circa 1208–1211.
- **Migration to Qonya:** After traveling through Bagdād, Mekka, Damascus, and Armenia, the family settled in Larenda and finally Qonya (Iconium) at the invitation of the Seljūqī Sultan, 'Alā'u-'d-Dīn Kayqubād.
- **Precocious Sanctity:** As a child of five, Jelāl was already prone to spiritual perturbations and visions of "Occult Existences." Anecdotes describe him vanishing from a rooftop to "visit the regions of God's realm" and manifesting signs of ocular vision of the divine by age seven.

II. The Influence of Shemsu-'d-Dīn Tebrīzī

The most significant turning point in Jelāl's life was his encounter with the "aggressive and domineering" Shemsu-'d-Dīn of Tebrīz.

- **The Meeting (1244 A.D.):** Shems arrived in Qonya pretending to be a merchant. He challenged Jelāl's intellectual learning by comparing the spiritual stations of Muhammed and Bāyezīd of Bestām. This encounter led to months of secluded spiritual communion.
- **Transformation of Practice:** Under Shems's influence, Jelāl abandoned his father's writings and his traditional professorial duties. He adopted the "Indian garb of mourning"—the drab hat and wide cloak—and instituted the musical services (the "holy dance") for which the order became known.
- **The Disappearance:** The intense relationship between the two drew fierce animosity from Jelāl's disciples. In 1246, Shems mysteriously disappeared. Some traditions suggest he was murdered by a mob (in which Jelāl's son 'Alā'u-'d-Dīn was implicated) and his body thrown down a well.

III. The Composition and Purpose of the Mesnevī

The *Mesnevī* is presented as a "science of divine intuition" dictated by Jelāl in his later years.

Origins and Amanuensis

The work was initiated at the request of Jelāl's pupil, **Husāmu-'d-Dīn Hasan**. Husām noticed the disciples were reading the works of other poets (like Sanā'ī and 'Attār) and suggested Jelāl write a original work in a similar style. Jelāl produced the first eighteen couplets immediately, claiming he had already been forewarned by God of this need.

The Methodology of "Sweet Sounds"

Jelāl explained the necessity of music, the flute (reed-flute), and the dance as a "salutary medicine" for the "Romans" (the inhabitants of Asia Minor). He perceived them as having a lively disposition but lacking a taste for spiritual mysteries. Music served as the "jam or honey" to tempt them toward a devotional love for God.

Structural Facts

Feature,Details

Total Couplets,"26,660"

Volumes,6 (a 7th is sometimes attributed to Sultān Veled)

Metre,Remel (hexameter contracted)

Key Themes,"Religion, History, Morals, and Politics"

IV. Spiritual Philosophy and Ethics

The anecdotes portray a philosophy centered on the annihilation of the self and the primacy of the spiritual master.

- **The "Three Pearls":** According to Jelāl, God offered Adam three pearls: **Wisdom, Faith, and Modesty**. These three are inseparable; where wisdom dwells, faith and modesty follow.

- **The Necessity of a Teacher:** Jelāl taught that a true disciple must hold their teacher as superior to all others, for the "men of God" are the substitutes of God on earth. "Without the blessing of his pious elders, a young man will never live to be old."
- **Humility:** He likened the spiritual man to a fruit-bearing tree: "Every tree that yields no fruit... grows tall and straight... whereas all the fruit-bearing trees droop their heads and trail their branches."
- **Divine Presence in All Things:** Jelāl taught that God comprises the "exterior and the interior." He asserted that even the braying of an ass or the croaking of frogs are forms of doxology, though humans often fail to hear them.

V. Miracles and Manifestations (Kerāmāt)

The text records hundreds of miracles attributed to Jelāl and his successors, intended to prove their status as "heirs of the prophets."

- **Control Over Nature:** Jelāl is said to have silenced a marsh of frogs that interrupted his discourse, turned pebbles into rubies for a needy disciple, and remained for seven days in the freezing waters of a cavern without physical change.
- **Precognition and Bi-location:** He was seen defending Damascus from the Mongols while physically present in Qonya. He also correctly identified the contents of a sealed gold box (a young snake) provided by the Sultan as a test.
- **Healing and Resurrection:** Anecdotes describe him restoring crushed limbs, curing fevers by writing invocations, and even momentarily calling a dead flute-player back to life.

VI. Death and Legacy

Jelālu-'d-Dīn died in December 1273 A.D. His passing was marked by significant cosmic and social events.

1. **The Final Days:** Before his death, severe earthquakes lasted seven days. He instructed his disciples to remain constant in fasting, worship, and the avoidance of "fleshly lusts." His last indited ode spoke of the "warder" from his love's abode beckoning him home.
 2. **Universal Mourning:** His funeral was attended by Muslims, Jews, Christians, Turks, Romans, and Arabs. The non-Muslims claimed they found in him "the Moses, the David, the Jesus of our time."
 3. **The Succession:**
 4. **Husāmu-'d-Dīn Hasan:** Served as successor for ten years until 1284 A.D.
 5. **Sultān Veled:** Jelāl's son, who organized the order and composed his own *Mesnevis* poems.
 6. **Chelebī Emīr 'Ārif:** Jelāl's grandson, who continued the travels and expansion of the order.
- Final Note on the Dervish Path:** The text defines the dervishes as "Gnostics" who style themselves "Poor, Impassioned, Adepts, and Perfect." Their goal is for the soul, an emanation from divine light, to be again congregated into the Glory of God.